The Stranger

Wretched is he whose childhood memories bring only fear and sadness. Wretched is he who turns his gaze towards solitary hours in vast and gloomy spaces. of brown curtains and amazing rows of ancient volumes, or towards terrifying vigils in the shade of enormous and grotesque trees, laden with vines, that they sway silently in the heights their twisted branches. Such is what the gods give me they assigned me, the bewildered, the frustrated, the barren, the ruined, and yet I feel strangely satisfied and I cling desperately to those withered memories each time that my mind threatens to go beyond, to the other side.

I don't know where I was born, except that the castle was infinitely horrible, full of passages. dark and with high ceilings where the gaze only found cobwebs and shadows. The the stones of the cracked corridors were always hatefully damp, and everywhere a foul smell was perceived, like piles of corpses from dead generations. Never there was light, so I would usually light candles and stare at them intently in search of relief; the sun did not shine outside either, as those terrible groves rose up above the tallest tower. Only one, a black tower exceeded the foliage and reached the sky open and unknown, but it was almost in ruins, and it could only be ascended by a steep wall almost impossible to climb.

I must have lived for years in that place, but I cannot measure time. Living beings They should have attended to my needs, and yet I cannot recall a person. except for myself, nor any living thing except rats, bats, and spiders, silent all.

I suppose that whoever took care of me must have been incredible. old, since my first mental representation of a living person was that of something similar to me, but twisted, wilted and deteriorated like the castle. To me, they had no nothing grotesque the bones and skeletons scattered through the crypts of the walls of carved stones deep in the foundations. In my fantasy, I associated those things with the everyday events and found them more real than the colorful figures of beings I saw living beings in many moldy books. In those books, I learned everything I know. Teacher someone urged or guided me, and I do not remember hearing voices in all those years.

humans..., not even mine; since although I had read about the spoken word never I thought of speaking aloud. My appearance was also something foreign to my mind. since there was no mirror in the castle and I instinctively limited myself to seeing myself as a being similar to the youthful figures I saw drawn or painted in the books. I had awareness of youth due to what little he remembered.

Outside, lying in the putrid pit, under the gloomy and silent trees, I used to spending whole hours dreaming about what I had read in the books; I longed to see myself among cheerful people, in the sunny world beyond the endless forest. Once again I tried to escape from the forest, but as I moved away from the castle, the shadows became more dense, and the air more filled with rising fears, so I started to run frantically along the path taken, lest I get lost in a labyrinth of gloom silence.

And so, through endless twilights, I dreamed and waited, even when I did not know what for. Until in my dark solitude, the desire for light became so frantic that I could no longer. remain inactive, and my pleading hands rose towards that solitary ruined tower that above the grove it sank into the exterior and unknown sky. And finally I decided climb the tower, even if I fell; since it was better to glimpse a moment of sky and to perish than to live without ever having contemplated the day.

In the damp twilight light, I climbed the ancient stone steps until I reached the level where they were interrupted, and from there on, climbing through small inlets where only one foot fit, I continued my dangerous ascent. Horrible and terrifying was that cylinder rocky, inert and without steps; black, ruinous and lonely, sinister with its silent fluttering of frightened bats. But even more horrifying was the slowness of my progress, as I more than creeping, the darkness that enveloped me did not dissipate and a new cold, like that of venerable and enchanted moho invaded me. Shivering from the cold, I wondered why not I was reaching the light, and had I dared, I would have looked down...

I felt as if night had suddenly fallen over me and I groped in vain with the hands free in search of the ledge of some window through which to spy out and up and to calculate at what height I was.

Suddenly, after a dreadful and endless ascent, blindly through that... concave and desperate cliff, I felt that my head touched something solid; I then knew that

I should have won the terrace or, at the very least, some kind of apartment. I raised my free hand and, in the darkness, I felt the obstacle, discovering that it was an immovable stone. Then came a mortal rodeo to the tower, clinging to any support that its viscous wall could provide to offer; until finally my hand, always groping, found a spot where the fence I yielded and resumed my ascent, pushing the slab or door with my head, since I used both hands in my cautious advance. No light appeared above, and as I progressed as my hands went higher and higher, I knew that my ascent had come to an end, as the the door opened to an opening that led to a larger stone surface circumference that the lower tower, undoubtedly the floor of some high and spacious chamber of observation. I silently slipped out of the chamber, trying not to let the heavy slab... I would return to my place, but I failed in my attempt. While I lay exhausted on the floor of stone, I heard the astonishing echo of its fall, but still, I had hope of returning to raise it when necessary.

Believing myself to be at a prodigious height, far above the hated branches of forest, I pulled myself up tiredly and felt along the wall in search of a window, that I allowed to see the sky for the first time, and that moon and those stars above which there had been read. But both hands disappointed me, as all I found were wide marble shelves, covered with abominable oblong boxes of disturbing dimensions. The more I reflected, the more I wondered what strange secrets that place could hold. built at such an immense distance from the castle. Suddenly my hands stumbled upon the door frame, from which hung a stone slab with a rough surface due to the strange cuts that covered him. The door was closed, but making a supreme effort, I overcame all the obstacles and opened it inward.

Having done this, the purest ecstasy I have ever known invaded me; through a ornamented iron gate, and at the end of a short staircase that ascended from the newly discovered door, shining peacefully in all its splendor, was the full moon, the one I had never seen before except in dreams and vague visions that I would not dare to call memories.

Surely I had now reached the top of the castle, I quickly climbed the few steps that separated me from the gate; but then a cloud covered one, making me to stumble, and in the darkness I had to move forward more slowly. It was still very dark

when I reached the gate, I found it open after a careful examination, but I did not want to I hesitated for fear of falling from the incredible height I had climbed. Then, the moon came out again.

Of all conceivable impacts, none as demonic as that of the unfathomable and grotesquely inconceivable. Nothing endured before could compare. with the terror of what I was now seeing; of the extraordinary wonders that the The show implied. The panorama itself was as simple as it was astonishing, as it consisted of merely in this: after an impressive perspective of treetops, views from an imposing height, spread around me, at the same level as the fence, nothing less than solid ground, separated into various compartments by means of slabs of marble and columns and shaded by an ancient stone church whose devastated capital shone phantasmagorically in the light of the moon.

Half-consciously, I opened the gate and walked along the white gravel path that it extended in two directions. No matter how bewildered and chaotic my mind was, it persisted in it. that yearning for light, and not even the astonishing discovery from before could stop me. No I knew, and I didn't care, whether my experience was madness, alienation, or magic, but I was resolved to pursue brightness and joy at all costs... I did not know who or what I was, nor what my scope or my circumstances could be; however, as I continued my stumbling march, a kind of timid latent memory began to insinuate itself in me that my progress was not entirely fortuitous. After passing the area of slabs and columns, I crossed a arcade and I started walking aimlessly across open fields; sometimes without losing sight of the path, others abandoning them to venture, filled with curiosity, into the prairies in the that only some occasional ruins revealed the presence, in remote times, of a path forgotten. At one point I had to swim across a fast river whose remains of Cracked and moldy masonry spoke of a bridge long disappeared.

More than two hours would have passed when I suddenly arrived at what truly it was my goal: a venerable castle, covered in ivy, nestled in a park of dense foliage, of astonishing familiarity to me, and yet, full of intriguing news. I saw that the moat had been filled and that several of the towers that I they knew were demolished, while new wings were rising that confused the audience. But what I observed with the utmost interest and delight were the windows.

open, flooded with glorious light that sent echoes of the happiest outside from the feasts. Advancing towards one of them, I looked inside and saw a group of strangely dressed people, who were chatting with great noise among themselves. As I had never seen before. I heard a human voice, I could barely guess what they were saying. Some faces had expressions that awakened in me very distant memories; others were absolutely foreign.

I jumped through the window and entered the brilliantly lit room. since my mind jumped from the only moment of hope to the darkest of discouragements. The nightmare did not take long to come, as soon as I entered, one of the most terrifying occurred. reactions that I could have conceived. I had not finished crossing the threshold when a sudden and unexpected fear, of horrible intensity, spread among all those present, it distorted faces and tore the most terrifying screams from all throats. The the rout was general, and in the midst of the shouting and panic, several fainted. being dragged by those who fled in madness. Many covered their eyes with the hands, and they ran blind taking everything in front of them, knocking over the furniture and hitting themselves with the walls in their desperate attempt to win one of the numerous doors.

Alone and dazed in the bright room, listening to the increasingly faint echoes from those chilling screams, I began to tremble thinking what that could be that it was stalking me without me seeing it. At first glance, it seemed empty, but when I turned to a from the rooms I thought I detected a presence, a hint of movement from the other side of a golden arch that led to another room, similar to the first. As I As I approached the archway, I began to perceive the presence more clearly; and then, with the first and last sound I ever made, a howl that disgusted me almost as much as its morbid cause, I contemplated in all its horrible intensity the inconceivable, indescribable, unfathomable monster that, by the mere act of its appearance, would have turned a joyful meeting in a horde of delirious fugitives.

I can't even say approximately what it looked like, as it was a compound. of all that is impure, terrifying, undesirable, abnormal, and detestable. It was a phantasmagoric shadow of decay, decrepitude, and desolation; the putrid and viscous image of the harmful: the atrocious nakedness of something that merciful earth should conceal forever and ever. God knows that it was not of this world –or at least had ceased to be–, and yet, to my immense horror, I could see in his corroded features,

bones that were glimpsed, a distant and repulsive reminiscence of human forms; and in their tattered and torn clothes, an indescribable quality that made me shudder even more.

I was almost paralyzed, but not so much that I couldn't make a weak effort towards the salvation; a stumble backward that could not break the spell in which it had me trapped the monster without voice and without name. My eyes, bewitched by those disgusting eyes glassy eyes that stared fixedly at them, refused to close, although the terrible object behind the first impact, it now looked more confusing. I tried to raise my hand and dissipate the vision, but I was so stunned that my arm did not fully respond to my will. Without embargo, the attempt was enough to alter my balance and, wobbling, I gave a few steps forward to avoid falling. In doing so, I suddenly acquired the distressing notion of the proximity of the thing, whose foul breath I could almost hear. Little less how crazy, I was able nevertheless to extend a hand to stop the foul image, which It was getting closer and closer, when suddenly, my hands touched the putrid extremity that the monster extended below the golden arch.

I didn't chill, but all the satanic vampires that ride in the night wind. they did it for me, while they dropped an avalanche of astounding things onto my mind memories.

I understood everything that had happened at that moment; I remembered even beyond the terrifying castle and its trees; and I recognized the building in which I was; I recognized the most terrible thing, the impious. abomination that stood before me, glancing at me sideways while distancing itself from its own my stained fingers.

But in the cosmos there is balm in addition to bitterness, and that balm is the I forgot. In the supreme horror of that moment, I forgot what had terrified me and the explosion. the memory faded into a chaos of repeated images. As if between dreams, I left that ghostly and cursed building, and I started to run swiftly and silently under the light of the moon. When I returned to the mausoleum and descended the steps, I found that I could not move. the stone trap; but I did not regret it, as I had come to hate the old castle and its trees. Now I ride alongside the ghosts, playful and cordial, in the night wind, and During the day, I play among the catacombs of Nefren-Ka, in the unknown and remote valley. from Hadoth, on the banks of the Nile. I know that light is not for me, except for the light of the moon on the rock tombs of Neb, nor is joy for me, except for the unnamed festivities

Transcription: Sarah Keziah Mason

of Nitokris under the Great Pyramid; and yet in my new and wild freedom, I am grateful almost the bitterness of alienation.

Well, even though forgetfulness has given me calmness, I do not ignore that I am a foreigner; a stranger to this century and to all those who are still men. This is what I knew. since I extended my fingers towards that abominable thing that emerged in that great frame golden; since I extended my fingers and touched a cold and inexorable polished surface mirror.

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